

Professor Emily M. Suazo

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You Can't Pause a Human Life

The moment that makes my stomach drop is not a courtroom scene. It's not a headline. It's the pause before a judge decides to defer my asylum case again. As an asylum seeker, you learn to live inside pauses. The pause before your next check in. The pause before your next hearing date. The pause between “received” and “decided.” I came to the United States from Tunisia. I am gay. I fled the death penalty.

Here, I do what the system tells me to do. Show up. Sign. Wait. Stay reachable. Stay compliant. People describe citizenship as the finish line, the place at the end of the marathon where you finally get to breathe. I used to believe that too. But when I look at some of the people who crossed that line, I see how often even “legal” is treated like a temporary condition, especially when the person is Muslim, African, or both. After Zohran Mamdani won New York City's mayoral election, Republican lawmakers pushed for investigations into his citizenship and advocated for denaturalization. Mamdani described this initiative as Islamophobic. Immigration experts told PolitiFact they saw no evidence he was ineligible for citizenship or that he misrepresented his background. (PolitiFact, Nov. 7, 2025; The Guardian, Oct. 26, 2025).

When you first come to the USA, you are told to “do it the right way”. The next day, you're barred from working for months. USCIS says asylum applicants are generally eligible for a work permit only after the asylum application has been pending for at least 180 days. (USCIS, Asylum

page, updated Nov. 7, 2025). So you wait. You try to save up money. You ration your food. Unfortunately, it doesn't deter the president from claiming that you're eating dogs and cats (Catalini et al.). Once you get your work permit, now you're "stealing jobs".

You're out of breath, yet, you still chase that American dream. You try to educate yourself. You learn the language of rights and humanitarian values at your university. However, you notice what happens when people try to apply those values out loud. Reuters reported that a Tufts University student from Turkey was detained after co-authoring an opinion piece criticizing her school's response to the war in Gaza, and a federal judge said her detention would hopefully discourage non-citizens from speaking out. The message is clear: learn, but don't practice too much. Speak, but not in a way that makes power nervous. Blind compliance is reflected as the ultimate solution. Therefore, you comply.

One day, you find out that the Trump administration froze asylum for everyone. The Associated Press reported that the administration halted all asylum decisions nationwide. Reuters reported that President Donald Trump vowed to "permanently pause" migration from what he called "Third World Shitholes". "Halted" is a word that belongs to machines. It sounds like a train delayed by weather, like an office closed for repairs. When the government pauses asylum, it doesn't pause a file. It pauses a life.

An asylum seeker learns to breathe in fragments. Not at home, because home taught you fear. Not fully in public, because you can be randomly detained by ICE (PBS NewsHour, Nov. 24, 2025). Not at work, because you are either forbidden to work or blamed if you do. Not in school,

because education can become evidence against you when you apply the values you were told to admire. In that kind of life, the lungs are always negotiating with power to catch a breath.

A refuge is not proven by speeches. A country that believes in due process does not punish whole populations for one alleged crime. A country that believes in equal citizenship does not flirt with denaturalization when a Muslim immigrant wins an election. A country that claims to value “legal” pathways can’t keep treating legal immigrants as disposable the moment they become visible, vocal, or successful. (Associated Press, Nov. 29, 2025; Reuters, Nov. 28, 2025; Human Rights Watch, Dec. 4, 2025).

When fear becomes policy, it doesn't just slow down paperwork, it teaches millions of people that belonging is conditional and reversible. And when the country makes that lesson loud enough, even those of us who follow every rule start to wonder whether the rules were ever meant for us to win. That’s why federal judges should block across-the-board pauses and refuse policies that shut out whole countries from seeking safety here, including people fleeing conflicts the United States was involved in.

A real finish line would mean the law is not a trap door, and that the promise of protection does not vanish the moment a politician needs someone to blame. I still want to believe there’s a finish line that matters, not just for people like Mamdani, running for office, but for people like me, still running after the American dream.